

Trump pact for schools targets USC

In response, Newsom threatens to pull funds from universities that comply with proposal.

BY JAWEED KALEEM, MELODY GUTIERREZ AND AAMER MADHANI

Gov. Gavin Newsom on Thursday threatened to cut “billions” in state funding, including to USC, from any California campus that signs a Trump administration compact and agrees to sweeping and largely conservative campus policies in exchange for priority access to federal funding.

“If any California University signs this radical agreement, they’ll lose billions in state funding — including Cal Grants — instantly,” Newsom said. “California will not bankroll schools that sell out their students, professors, researchers, and surrender academic freedom.”

The bold statement came less than a day after the White House asked the University of Southern California and eight other major universities throughout the country to shift to the right and agree to Trump’s views on gender identity, admissions, diversity and free speech among other areas — in exchange for more favorable access to federal research grants and additional funding.

While USC is the only California university to be sent the Trump proposal, a White House official said universities sent the agreement were a first round among potentially several more campuses that could receive the request. All UC and CSU campuses — in addition to Stanford — are under federal civil rights investigations that could result in federal funding clawbacks.

Universities were asked to sign a “Compact for Academic Excellence in Higher Education” committing them to adopt the White House’s conservative vision for America’s campuses. [See **Funding**, A8]



A MAN, top, reclines under the 405 Freeway last month in Culver City. Above, Anthony Bacon and his daughter Cherish have lunch in July at a Pasadena shelter.

Botched data on shelters aggravate homeless crisis

Nonprofits say system is often inaccurate and makes it more difficult to provide housing.

BY ANDREW KHOURI AND DOUG SMITH

In early August, data from the Los Angeles Homeless Services Authority showed only two out of 88 beds at an East Hollywood homeless shelter were occupied, a shockingly low rate in a county where some 47,000 sleep on the streets.

There’s just one big problem, according to the nonprofit PATH, which operates the shelter. The data were dead wrong. PATH’s internal data showed 84

beds were filled.

For years, LAHSA has worked on a system to provide “real-time” information on availability at interim housing sites, promising it would wipe away an arcane “matching” process and fill more beds and fill them quicker.

But since the system rolled out, nonprofits that operate interim housing for LAHSA said it can be difficult to work with, and the data it produces are frequently inaccurate, providing the public with a skewed view of reality and potentially making it harder — not easier — to get people off the streets.

“You have to know which interim housing sites can take” people, PATH Chief Executive Jennifer Hark Di-

etz said. “If it’s not accurate, you are actually sending people to a place that doesn’t have availability for them.”

LAHSA, a joint city-county agency established in 1993, has long faced criticism for not adequately tracking its programs and funds, potentially leaving them open to waste and fraud.

According to LAHSA, the process of placing people into shelter beds in L.A. County was cumbersome and time-consuming and relied on spreadsheets, phone calls and daily emails to track inventory and get people shelter. While LAHSA directly placed people into many beds, nonprofits handled the process at many [See **Shelters**, A14]

A TIMES INVESTIGATION

In \$4-billion abuse case, some say they were paid to sue

Seven people told The Times they were recruited outside a benefits office by vendors and received cash to make claims

BY REBECCA ELLIS

Every day, some of L.A.’s poorest residents line up outside the county benefits office in South Central, weaving their way through a swarm of salesmen hawking deals that feel too good to be true.

Would you like \$15 for a quick blood pressure exam? A free phone? Perhaps \$2 for a COVID swab?

How about cash to sign up to sue L.A. County for sexual abuse at juvenile halls?

Over the last year, a Times investigation found a practice of paying for plaintiffs among a nebulous network of vendors, who usher people desperate for cash toward a law firm that could profit significantly from their business.

The Times spent two weeks outside the county social services office in South Los Angeles, where a constant flow of people applied for food stamps and cash aid, and spoke with seven people who said they were paid there within the last year to sue the county for sex abuse.

Most said they were abused inside the county’s juvenile halls, but had not planned to sue until they were flagged down on the sidewalk and offered cash. Two people said they were told to fabricate stories of abuse.

All the claims involving alleged payments were filed by Downtown L.A. Law Group, a pivotal player in the county’s recent \$4-billion settlement for sex abuse inside its juvenile halls and foster homes — the largest such payout in U.S. history. Of the roughly 11,000 plaintiffs in the settlement, The Times found that nearly one-fourth were represented by the firm.

Marlon Bland, 31, said he got \$200 — half in cash outside the county’s social [See **Settlement**, A6]



K. C. ALFRED San Diego Union-Tribune

LORENA GONZALEZ backed law to give victims time to sue. She’s bothered by how it turned out.

Shutdown fuels mass layoff threat

Trump seeks federal workforce shake-up and ‘irreversible’ cuts to Democratic plans.

BY LISA MASCARO, JOSH BOAK AND SEUNG MIN KIM

WASHINGTON — President Trump has seized on the government shutdown as an opportunity to reshape the federal workforce and punish detractors, meeting with budget director Russ Vought on Thursday to talk through “temporary or permanent” spending cuts that could set up a lose-lose dynamic for Democratic lawmakers.

Trump announced the meeting on social media Thursday morning, saying he and Vought would determine “which of the many Democrat Agencies” would be cut — continuing their efforts to slash federal spending by threatening mass firings of workers and suggesting “irreversible” cuts to Democratic priorities.

“I can’t believe the Radical Left Democrats gave me this unprecedented opportunity,” Trump wrote on his social media account. “They are not stupid people, so maybe this is their way of wanting to, quietly and quickly, MAKE AMERICA GREAT AGAIN!”

Trump has been very direct about his intentions in saying that he believes the Democrats would get the blame if he chooses to fire people or cut spending as [See **Shutdown**, A7]

California climate projects are hit

The Trump administration says it will cancel billions in funding in 16 states. **CALIFORNIA**, B1

Legal fight over troops escalates

Experts question Trump’s call to use American cities as military “training grounds.” **NATION**, A5

Dodgers’ biggest test coming next

The rested and balanced Phillies have virtually no weakness, Bill Plaschke writes. **SPORTS**, B10

Project includes a floating garden

A \$10-billion luxury housing and hotel complex is planned for Beverly Hills. **BUSINESS**, A10

Weather

A morning sprinkle. L.A. Basin: 78/60. **B6**

Markets **A12**

Opinion Voices **A13**



CHRISTINA HOUSE Los Angeles Times

DANA GOLLER is a security guard in the only RV in a Harbor City RV park lot.

An L.A. neighborhood draws a hard line over this RV park

BY NOAH GOLDBERG

John Montagna is ready to move into a new RV park in the Green Meadows West section of Harbor City, near his job as a longshoreman.

But he is still making a two-hour commute from Bakersfield, after opposition from neighbors helped stall the opening of the park.

“Save Green Meadows West” signs have popped up on many lawns as residents express fears about crime

and declining property values, while people such as Montagna say the park, called Ocean’s II, offers an affordable option amid the area’s sky-high rents.

“There’s people that live nice in RVs,” said Montagna, who plans to pay \$1,250 a month to live at the park in his 2021 Tiffin Allegro Bus. “Anybody who moves into any neighborhood can be a safety issue. You can’t be stereotyping just ‘cause it’s an RV park.”

Nicole Paulsen, who lives

on President Avenue about a block from the proposed RV park, worries about a “Breaking Bad” scenario of drugs and violence, noting issues with RVs illegally parked nearby on Western Avenue. She said the RV park’s developer has not adequately included neighbors in the planning process.

“It’s not going to be our neighborhood anymore,” said Paulsen, who grew up in San Pedro and moved to Green Meadows West in 2019 [See **RV park**, A14]

AI actor causes a real-life scandal

The claim that Tilly Norwood will sign with a talent agency generates a backlash.

BY WENDY LEE

Scary. Terrifying. Deeply misguided.

Those were among the visceral reactions this week from Emily Blunt, Whoopi Goldberg, Natasha Lyonne and many other actors and filmmakers over the sudden fame of Tilly Norwood.

Norwood isn’t real — the brunet woman who appears in a comedy sketch on her Instagram page is in fact a computer-generated composite.

“I may be AI, but I’m feeling very real emotions right now,” states a message on Norwood’s Instagram page. “I am so excited for what’s coming next!”

The sentiment was not widely shared, at least in Hollywood, where anxieties about the use and abuse of artificial intelligence replacing actors run deep. [See **AI actor**, A12]